



Surging ahead: After a 2025 season in which she crossed \$1 million in prize money and won 94.8 per cent of her matches, An Se-young (R) has only raised the bar further. AFP

competed against her and there is a mix of awe and exasperation as they try to explain why it is so hard to get the better of the Korean.

"She's unbelievable. She's just one of those once-in-a-generation players," says Scotland's Kirsty Gilmour, who is on the wrong end of a 0-7 record against An. "Sometimes you're worried about, you think, where can I win just one point? Because in so many ways, she is just a machine. She's a robot. She just is. She finds a way to win, and she just

goes hard at that. I think she should be studied for generations to come."

Canada's Michelle Li, who trails An 0-9, can vouch for the Korean's tenacity and unwillingness to lose. In two of the last three encounters between the pair, the Canadian won the opening game before An took control. "There's that mental aspect of it, too (to beat her). I came close (at the Malaysia Open), but even though I was leading, you still can't take your foot off the gas against her. That's what makes her so good," says Li.

It is hard to say just where An stands in the pantheon of greats. Her record certainly puts her in rarefied air. As someone who has been playing on the international circuit for a decade and a half,

Ratchanok says it is not easy to compare the Korean with the other greats of women's badminton.

"Tai Tzu Ying (3-12 against An) and Carolina Marin (4-6 against An) both have different styles. An has a different style," she says.

Ratchanok does not have to think too hard when comparing her against players from the current generation. "She's a bit above this generation of players," she says.

High praise

The only players who have met An on even terms are the very best women's badminton has produced over the last decade. Even Tokyo Olympic champion Chen Yufei, who inflicted two of the four defeats An suffered last season, admits just how